trophic levels is equal to the number of steps in the food chain. The green plants (producers) occupying the first trophic level (T_1) are called **producers**. The energy produced by the producers is utilized by the plant eaters (herbivores) they are called **primary consumers** and occupy the second trophic level (T_2).

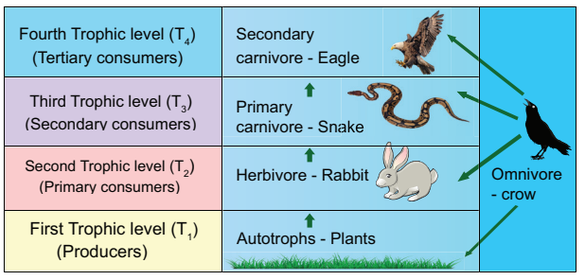


Figure 7.1: Diagrammatic representation of trophic levels

Herbivores are eaten by carnivores, which occupy the third trophic level (T_3). They are also called **secondary consumers** or **primary carnivores**. Carnivores are eaten by the other carnivores, which occupy the fourth trophic level (T_4). They are called the **tertiary consumers or secondary carnivores**. Some organisms which eat both plants and animals are called as **omnivores** (Crow). Such organisms may occupy more than one trophic level in the food chain.

7.2.4 Energy flow

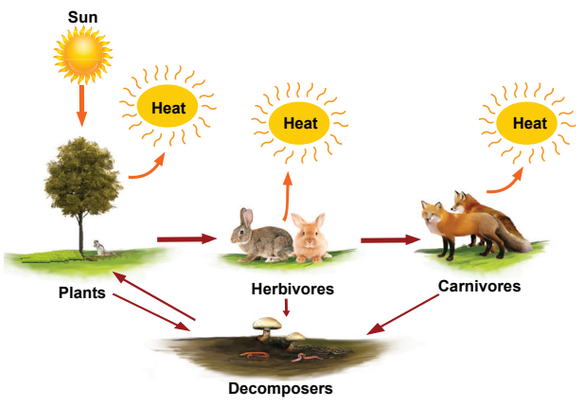


Figure 7.2: Diagrammatic representation of energy flow

The transfer of energy in an ecosystem between trophic levels can be termed as energy flow. It is the key function in an ecosystem. Part of the energy obtained from the sun by producers are transferred to consumers and decomposers through each trophic level, while some amount of energy is dissipated in the form of heat. Energy flow is always unidirectional in an ecosystem.

Laws of thermodynamics

The storage and loss of energy in an ecosystem is based on two basic laws of thermo-dynamics.

i. First law of thermodynamics

It states that energy can be transmitted from one system to another in various forms. Energy cannot be destroyed or created. But it can be transformed from one form to another. As a result, the quantity of energy present in the universe is constant.

Example:

In photosynthesis, the product of starch (chemical energy) is formed by the combination of reactants (chlorophyll, H_2O, CO_2). The energy stored in starch is acquired from the external sources (light energy) and so there is no gain or loss in total energy. Here light energy is converted into chemical energy.

$$6\,CO_2 + 6\,H_20 \xrightarrow[\text{Chlorophyll}]{\text{light}} C_6H_{12}0_6 + 6\,O_2$$

$$\text{Light energy} \longrightarrow \text{chemical energy}$$

ii. Second law of thermodynamics

It states that energy transformation results in the reduction of the free energy of the system. Usually energy transformation cannot be 100% efficient. As energy is transferred from one organism to another in the form of food, a portion of it is stored as energy in living tissue, whereas a large part of energy is dissipated as heat through respiration. The transfer of energy is irreversible natural process. Example: Ten percent law

Ten percent law

This law was proposed by Lindeman (1942). It states that during transfer of food energy from one trophic level to other, only about 10% stored at every level and rest of them (90%) is lost in

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